UNIVERSITY Of GUYANA
FACULTY OF EDUCATION AND HUMANITIES
DEPT. Research and Graduate Studies
Course: EFN 5106 The Adolescent Learner
TOPIC: PSYCHOLOGY AS A SCIENCE OF BEHAVIOUR
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Psychology - ***Is the scientific study of behaviour and mental processes.***

- Describes, explains, predict and controls the events it studies,
- Do not control the behaviour of people, but help clients to modify behaviour for their own benefits,
- Is used to organise thoughts (one must understand behaviour to modify it).

SCIENCE – refers to a system of acquiring knowledge (based on observation and experimentation to describe and explain natural phenomena. Is just another way of gathering knowledge, and it has its own way of answering questions and solving conflicts between different explanations.

The FOUR aims of Science are:

1. **Description** – is to achieve objective description of events.

2. **Prediction** – this arrives from good, objective description, which reveals patterns and thus makes prediction possible.

3**. Understanding** – if predictions turn out to be reliable, the scientist can go on tom study the relationship between cause and effect.

4. **Control** – accurate prediction and thorough understanding put the scientist in the position of being able to arrange for an event to happen and thus control it. The rigorous design of an investigation to eliminate as far as possible all sources of bias.

Assumptions of Science

1. Order – Scientists believe that events in the world are not random and haphazard. The implication of this is that it is possible to discover regularities and patterns (order) which will eventually lead to the formulation of laws. It is therefore, possible to discover laws of behaviour.

2. Determinism – If there is order in events, then it makes sense to assume that they are causally related. The implication is that no psychological event is irrational.
Is a belief that all human behaviour is caused by internal and/or external forces over which one has no control.

3**. Empiricism** – An approach that advocates the collection of information through the senses rather than by faith or by hearsay.

4. **Parsimony** – When applied to research, an economical explanation that does not go beyond the available data. `

Psychology – is the science that studies behaviour and mental processes.

Theory is the tool used by psychologists to organise their thoughts when explaining phenomena or events. A theory is a general system for explaining the underlying principles of a phenomenon.
Interwoven into theories are concepts and descriptive terms, where theories are found to be formulations of apparent relationships underlying observed events (Rathus, 1996; Birren et al, 1981).

In the behavioural sciences**, 4 functions of the use of theory are to:**

i. Provide a good understanding of human behaviour.

ii. Predict the likely course of behaviour.

iii. Control behaviour.

iv. Suggest directions for research.

The human being is a complex organism, thus a number of views have been expressed and formulated to explain development and behaviour. Many theories combine statements of behaviour, for example, eating or aggression, mental processes (attitudes and mental images) and anatomical structures or biological processes.

Developmental Changes

A persons' life between conception and death involves many developmental changes. As these unique changes evolve, they lead to progress in the life of a person. Changes can be attributed to inherent genetic programming, for example, the expectations of an individual would be that they would grow taller, gain weight and experience puberty at appropriate ages. The nature and timing of these events, occur almost automatically over the life span of the human being.

Other changes, which are less predictable, result from influences other than biology. People learn to behave as expected due to the values and expectations of society and the family. Thus, most developmental changes are found to be the product of interaction between biological preset mechanisms and environmental factors. It is important then to learn how inherent and learned influences work together to shape the changes individuals experience over their lifetime.

Human development is an interdisciplinary field based on the academic areas of psychology, sociology, human biology and anthropology. Studies on human development aims at acquiring a better understanding of human beings so that the quality of life can be improved.

Psychology tells us:

- About human development changes
- What is the basic nature of human beings
- Why human beings behave the way they do
- What are the predictable ways in which people grow
- About genetic background.

Psychology Answers questions on:

- How people learn
- How we can motivate learners
- How to identify readiness for learning
- How to help learners establish realistic goals
- How to make people better learners
- How to execute effective discipline
- How to deal with misbehaviour
- How to increase effectiveness of instruction.

Educational Psychology Deals with:

- learning processes
- motivation
- social learning
- human personality
- measurement and evaluation

Schools of Psychology

Psychology developed as a discipline which was founded on the use of empirical methods, through observation and the collection of data. As a result, a number of schools of thought emerged. Schools, in this context, are groups of psychologists who held common beliefs, about both the subject matter of psychology - what facets of mental functioning should be studied and what methods should be used (Malim & Birch, 1998)

<u>Psychoanalysis</u>

Development is primarily unconscious (that is, beyond awareness) and is heavily colored by emotions.

- A view developed by Sigmund Freud (1856 - !939) that emphasises the interplay of unconscious mental processes in determining human thoughts, feelings, behaviour and personality.
- Erik Erikson (1902 – 1994) says we develop in psychosocial stages. Emphasises developmental change throughout the human lifespan.

Behaviourism

- Strong emphasis on how an individual's interaction with environmental events shape change in behaviour throughout the life span
- View the human being as a passive responder to environmental stimuli

Theorists - B F Skinner, Ivan Pavlov, Bandura, Thorndike, Watson. 3.

Humanism

- Centers on human interests and values and the capacity of individuals to fulfill their potentials.

People are conscious, self-aware and capable of free choice, self-fulfilment and ethical behaviour.

- Major emphasis is placed on the establishment and development of nurturant, non-threatening

situations which would help/allow an individual to develop to their fullest potential.

Theorists – Abraham Maslow and Carl Rogers

Cognition (development of the intellect)

- Focuses on knowing. Explains development of understanding, emphasizes the importance of meaningfulness and organization.

Theorists – Ausubel, Bruner, Piaget

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